



MICHAL WALUSZA

Indeed, R. Vaishali was the discovery of the Candidates, for which she had qualified by emerging as the surprise champion of the Grand Swiss in November. After becoming the country's third female Grandmaster, she had rightfully earned her spot.

Equally, she was not expected to make a splash in the Candidates since she hardly had opportunities to play with the elite.

But she did.

Rated seventh in the field of eight players, Vaishali had a highly forgettable first half despite a decent

start. In the first three rounds, she was part of all three possible results, with her victory coming over the lowest seed, Salimova, in the third round.

However, the victory was to remain the brightest part for Vaishali for the next six rounds, since she lost the last four rounds of the first half.

When she ended the first half with two defeats and resumed the second half with two losses, Vaishali's campaign appeared to be in tatters.

She lost a few games by committing early blunders and the rest by playing moves of suboptimal strength in crucial positions.

What followed was simply sensational and unforeseeable. She won the remaining five rounds to finish as joint runner-up.

Notably, her victims included top seed Aleksandra Goryachkina, second seed Lei Tingjie, fourth seed Kateryna Lagno, and former World Championship runner-up Anna Muzychuk.

Beating Goryachkina and Lagno, the two Russians in the fray, was clearly a big takeaway for Vaishali.

R. Vaishali

Rank

Tied 2nd

Seeding

7

Rating

2475

Performance Rating

2552

Rating points gained

14.2

Points scored 7.5/14

Rd	Seed	Opponent	Country	Rating	Colour	Result	Rank
1	3	K. Humpy	India	2546	White	Draw	Tied 2nd
2	5	Tan Zhongyi	China	2521	Black	Lost	1st
3	8	Nurgyul Salimova	Bulgaria	2432	White	Won	Tied 7th
4	1	Aleksandra Goryachkina	FIDE	2553	Black	Draw	5th
5	6	Anna Muzychuk	Ukraine	2520	White	Draw	Tied 7th
6	4	Kateryna Lagno	FIDE	2542	White	Lost	6th
7	2	Lei Tingjie	China	2550	Black	Lost	Tied 2nd
8	3	K. Humpy	India	2546	Black	Lost	Tied 2nd
9	5	Tan Zhongyi	China	2521	White	Lost	1st
10	8	Nurgyul Salimova	Bulgaria	2432	Black	Won	Tied 7th
11	1	Aleksandra Goryachkina	FIDE	2553	White	Won	5th
12	6	Anna Muzychuk	Ukraine	2520	Black	Won	Tied 7th
13	2	Lei Tingjie	China	2550	White	Won	Tied 2nd
14	4	Kateryna Lagno	FIDE	2542	Black	Won	6th